

Food regulators from around the world are gathering in Cairns today for the 27th Codex Committee on Food Import and Export Inspection and Certification Systems (CCIFCS).

Delegates to the weeklong gathering will be working to harmonise food import and export standards crucial to international trade and global food security.

Chaired by Australia, CCFICS sets standards that help ensure food safety for consumers and reduce barriers to trade for food exporters and importers globally.

By harmonising regulatory standards related to food import and export inspection and certification, the committee's work benefits farmers, food businesses, regulators, consumers and other supply chain stakeholders.

Deputy Secretary for Agricultural Trade and Regulation Tina Hutchison said more than 220 delegates from 60-plus countries would work collectively to shape international food standards at this week's Cairns session.

"CCFICS standards support the design and operation of national food control systems to ensure food is safe," Ms Hutchison said.

"They provide a transparent framework to promote fair practices in the international food trade.

"This week we will continue developing international guidelines on the prevention and control of food fraud; equivalence of countries' food controls and traceability and product tracing in national food control systems.

"The international harmonisation of food safety approaches within countries' national food control systems and their import and export inspection and certification systems helps facilitate trade, reduce regulatory costs and protect the health of consumers."

The committee will also consider proposals on new work relating to information exchange in food import and export inspection and certification systems, including the use of digital technologies and AI, standardisation of electronic certification, food establishment listings and imported food rejection guidance.

CCFICS is a subsidiary body of the Codex Alimentarius Commission (Codex), – the international food standards program of the United Nations Food and Agriculture Organisation and the World Health Organization (WHO).

Codex food standards are the benchmark under the World Trade Organisation (WTO) Agreement on the Application of Sanitary and Phytosanitary Measures, with WTO signatories expected to align with Codex.

Australia is hosting the 27th CCFICS session from today until Friday after hosting and chairing 26 sessions since the inaugural meeting in 1992.

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/global-food-standards-cairns>